

Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος

Aelius Aristides of Smyrna on God and Humanity

eul_aid: pnc

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Ἀττική [Attic](#)
Domain: Θεολογία [Theology](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Aelius Aristides was a Greek orator and author of the second century CE, a period of Roman rule known as the Second Sophistic. Born to a wealthy family in 117 CE, he was educated in rhetoric and philosophy and became a prominent citizen of the city of Smyrna.

His life was dramatically altered by a severe, chronic illness beginning around 144 CE. He sought healing at the sanctuary of the god Asclepius in Pergamum, where he spent years following the god's dream-based prescriptions. Aristides was a prolific writer, and over fifty of his works survive. His most famous composition is the Sacred Tales, a unique six-book autobiography detailing his illness and religious experiences at the sanctuary. He also wrote numerous formal orations, including speeches praising cities like Rome and Smyrna, hymns to various gods, and rhetorical defenses of his profession.

Aristides is a figure of major historical importance. His Sacred Tales provide an unparalleled firsthand account of ancient medicine, personal religion, and the practice of seeking healing dreams in a temple. His ceremonial speeches, especially his oration Regarding Rome, are crucial sources for understanding how Greek intellectuals viewed the Roman Empire at its height. Furthermore, his mastery of classical Greek style ensured his works were preserved and used as models for rhetoric and education for centuries after his death, which occurred around 181 CE.

Works (3)

- Ἀπολογητικά Χριστιανικά Ἀποσπάσματα · [Christian Apologetic Fragments](#) · 3 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα · [On the Nature of God and Humanity](#) · 52 passages
- Φιλοσοφικά Ἀποσπάσματα · [Philosophical Fragments](#) · 2 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- Ἀχιλλεύς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · [Achilles Tattius of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός · [Aelian of Praeneste](#) · 4 works
- Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς · [Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus](#) · 1 work
- Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής · [Aelius Theon the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς · [Alcidamas of Elaea](#) · 1 work
- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · [Alciphron the Sophist](#) · 1 work

- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · Alexander Son of Numenius · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Alexander the Ephesian Poet · 1 work
- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Antiphon of Athens · 9 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ῥαμνούσιος · Antiphon of Rhamnus · 1 work